

Germany's tanks on the eve of war

After World War I, Paragraph 24 of the Treaty of Versailles banned Germany from making tanks. However, German staff officers began secret experiments with tracked vehicles and cooperated with the Soviet Union in developing and testing armored tracked vehicles, while dummy vehicles were constructed on car chassis to train with. General Oswald Lutz and his chief of staff, Lieutenant Colonel Heinz Guderian, promoted the idea of tanks grouped together in armored divisions. Guderian thought three types of tanks would be necessary: a huge breakthrough tank to smash fortifications; an infantry tank to accompany the infantry on the attack; and a cruiser tank to advance behind enemy lines once a breakthrough had been achieved.

When Hitler came to power in 1933, he saw the propaganda value of tanks and supported their development. Guderian in turn simplified his requirements to two types—the infantry support tank (which became the Panzer IV) and a general purpose cruiser (the Panzer III). As German industry developed the III and IV designs with some difficulty, the Panzer I was also put into production to create a training tank for the German Army. It was superseded by the Panzer II, which went on to be one of the most common tanks of the early war years.

A German Panzer regiment shows off its Panzer I tanks at a rally in Kamenz, Saxony in 1936.

